1Ask Mavis: Full Business Plan

Nov 9, 2026 · @Sam

Summary

Ask Mavis can start for about £560, start making money each month from month 4, pay itself back by month 9, and on the expected plan make about £820 profit in year 1 (after start-up costs), £7,600 in year 2 and £13,500 in year 3, before tax.

What it is	A UK phone app for older people. Say what's wrong; Mavis shows you how to fix it, one simple step at a time, read out loud.
Who it's for	Older people with a smartphone who get stuck, and their grown-up children who are the family's unpaid IT department.
Who pays	The older person, or their son or daughter as a gift. Everything that keeps people safe is free; unlimited "ask anything" help is £2.99 a month or £24.99 a year.
How we find customers	Mostly free: word of mouth, local press, free help sessions and charity partners. Facebook ads at £100 a month are used to learn and to get the first users.
Money needed	About £560 to start, with at most about £520 at risk at the lowest point. No loan or investor needed.
Where it is now	The Android app is built and installable. Still to do: put the server online, add payments, test with 15 people, and get on Google Play.

This plan builds on the earlier *Ask Mavis: Business & Marketing Plan* and the *Marketing Playbook*, and puts all the money in one place. All figures are estimates; the biggest unknown is how many people come by word of mouth, so the plan also shows a worse case and a better case.

The problem and the market

Millions of older people in the UK have a smartphone but get stuck, and the things they get stuck on (the GP, banking, parking, ordering screens) are now hard to avoid.

- **13.4 million** people in the UK are 65 or over, and Age UK says **4.7 million** of them can't do the basic things the internet now needs (ICAEW on ONS projections; Age UK, *Offline and Overlooked*).
- Booking a GP appointment, banking and paying for parking increasingly need an app or a website (Age UK campaign; Digital Health, 2026).
- About **75%** of over-65s use social media, and Facebook reaches **93%** of UK adults who are online (Ofcom 2025, via Delivered Social). Our customers are reachable.
- **6.6 million** people worry they wouldn't know how to support their older parents (Age UK, 2023). That is the second buyer.

Our customer is not someone fully offline (they won't download an app). It's someone who has a smartphone, uses WhatsApp and Facebook, and feels embarrassed asking for help again.

How big a slice we need. If 4.7 million struggle and even a fifth of them have a smartphone they use, that's about 900,000 people. The year 3 forecast needs about 1,000 paying subscribers: roughly **1 in 900** of them. That is a small, realistic share.

Competitors

Who	What it is	Price	What we do better
Siggi	Voice help for phone settings	$8.49 on the App Store	Android too; covers the TV, Wi-Fi and out-and-about
Chat With Gil	Text chat helper	Free	Voice, read aloud, works offline
Helpmee.ai	Voice help with screen sharing	From about $10.86 a month	Simpler set-up, much cheaper
Paid human help	Remote or home visits	About $25 a month, or $120 an hour	A fraction of the price, there at 9pm
Age UK, AbilityNet	Free volunteers	Free	No waiting list. We're partners, not rivals

Our edge in one line: UK-made, voice-first, covers home and the high street, puts scams first, works with no internet, lets people practise, and costs less than a cup of coffee a month.

The product

The Android app is built and installs on a phone today; about four to six weeks of finishing work stands between it and Google Play.

Built and working now:

- One big "Tap and tell me" button that turns speech into text, plus a typing box and picture buttons.
- A "What's happening?" picker for one-word problems like "Netflix!" or "The telly!".
- About 35 built-in step-by-step guides that work with no internet: the TV and Netflix, phones, WhatsApp and photos, the GP and prescriptions, banking, scams, ordering screens, self-checkouts, parking and cash machines.
- "Is this a scam?" checker, with a one-tap button to ring 159.
- "What is…?" answers for about 50 tech words, like "What is AI?".
- Today's brain teaser: three questions a day, with stars, a day streak and badges.
- Practice mode: a pretend takeaway ordering screen with a coach.
- "Show Mavis a photo" of a confusing screen (needs the server).
- Cheerful sounds, reading aloud, big text, and Call or Text a family helper.
- A small server that asks Claude to write a guide for anything the built-in guides don't cover.

Before launch: put the server online with a Claude API key, add Plus subscriptions through Google Play, write the privacy policy, test with 15 older people, and submit to Google Play.

After launch, in this order: a "Tell a friend" button (gives a friend a free month), a review prompt on the "Well done!" screen, Family gift set-up from the giver's phone, and the iPhone version at the start of year 2, once the app is paying for itself.

Pricing

Safety is always free; unlimited "ask anything" help is £2.99 a month or £24.99 a year, and Google keeps 15% of it.

Plan	Price	What's in it	You keep after Google's 15%
Free	£0, forever	All built-in guides, pickers, scam checker, "What is…?", brain teaser, practice mode, Call family, and 3 "ask anything" questions a month	£0
Plus, monthly	£2.99 a month	Unlimited "ask anything" help and "Show Mavis a photo"	£2.54 a month
Plus, yearly	£24.99 a year (about £2.08 a month)	The same, with two months free	£21.24 a year
Family gift	£24.99 a year	Plus for Mum or Dad, bought and set up by a son or daughter	£21.24 a year

Why this is fair:

- No one is charged to stay safe. The scam checker and all built-in guides are free.
- It's cheaper than every paid alternative: Siggi is $8.49, and human help starts around $25 a month.
- No adverts, no selling data, no tricks. A reminder before a yearly plan renews, and cancelling takes two taps.

Why it still makes money: one "ask anything" question costs about **3p** in Claude fees. Even a heavy user asking 10 questions a month costs about 30p, against £2.54 coming in. Google's 15% applies to small developers earning under $1 million a year (Adapty).

Marketing

Ads alone cost about £53 per paying customer, more than two years of their subscription, so ads are for learning and the free channels do most of the work; across everything, a paying customer costs about £7 in year 1.

The full detail is in the *Marketing Playbook*. In short:

Channel	What we do	Cost
Facebook and Instagram ads	Short videos of the app working, aimed at older people and at their grown-up children ("Gift it for £24.99 a year"). A £300 test in launch month, then keep only the best ad	£300, then £100 a month
Local press and radio	"Grandson builds an app after his nan struggled with the McDonald's screen"	Free
Free help sessions	20-minute "fix your phone" sessions at libraries, U3A, WI, lunch clubs and sheltered housing	Free, plus your time
Leaflets and noticeboards	The A5 leaflet at GP surgeries, chemists, community centres and supermarkets	About £30 per 500
Charities and councils	Free Plus codes for Age UK branches, AbilityNet and council digital inclusion teams to hand out	Free
Facebook groups	Post the demo videos in local community and carers' groups, with the admin's permission	Free
Inside the app	"Tell a friend" (a free month each), a review prompt on "Well done!"	Free

Marketing budget

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Facebook ads	£1,400 (£300, then £100 a month)	£1,800 (£150 a month)	£3,000 (£250 a month)
Leaflets and printing	£60	£120	£150
Total	**£1,460**	**£1,920**	**£3,150**

What a customer costs

- **From ads alone:** £100 buys about 38 installs (UK averages of 30p to £1.50 a click; Studio Liddell, SuperAds). About 5% of installs pay, so that's about 2 paying customers: **about £53 each.**
- **Across all channels in year 1:** about £1,460 of marketing brings about 3,800 installs and 190 paying customers: **about £7.70 each.**
- **What a customer is worth:** a yearly subscriber who renews once is worth about £42 after Google's cut. A monthly subscriber stays about 17 months on average (6% cancel each month), worth about £43.

The rule: only raise the ad budget once ads bring a paying customer for under £21, one year's income.

Start-up costs

You can launch for about £560: £260 to get ready, then £300 of Facebook ads in launch month.

Item	Cost	Notes
ICO data protection fee	£52 a year (£47 by Direct Debit)	Required: the app handles personal data
Google Play developer account	About £20, once	$25 one-off
Testing with 15 older people	£150	A £10 voucher, or tea and cake, each
Claude API credit	£20	Pay as you go, with a spending limit
Domain name	About £15 a year	For the website and email
Registering the business	£0	Sole trader with HMRC is free; a limited company is £100
App building, logo, website	£0	Expo's free build tier, Canva, a free one-page site
Ready to launch	**About £260**	
Facebook ads, launch month	£300	£10 a day for 30 days
Total to launch	**About £560**	

Left out on purpose until the app pays for itself: the Apple Developer Program (about £80 a year, added in year 2), insurance (about £100 to £200 a year, approximate, get quotes), and a trademark (£170 for one class online at the UK IPO, more for extra classes).

Monthly running costs

Apart from ads, running Ask Mavis costs about £25 a month in year 1 and £45 a month from year 2, plus about 30p per paying subscriber for Claude.

Fixed costs, every month

Item	Year 1	Year 2 onwards	Notes
Server hosting	£5	£10	Free tiers at first, approximate
Yearly fees, spread out (ICO, domain)	£6	£6	
Apple Developer Program	£0	£7	About £80 a year, once iPhone is added
Insurance	£0	£13	About £150 a year, approximate
Leaflets and printing	£5	£10	
Phone, email and other bits	£9	£9	
Total fixed	**£25**	**£45**	

Costs that grow with users

Item	Cost	Notes
Claude, for paying subscribers	About 30p each a month	About 10 questions at 3p each (Claude Opus 5.5)
Claude, for free users	About 1p each a month	Allowing for 3 in 10 free users asking one question a month
Google's share	15% of each payment	Taken before the money reaches you, so not a bill

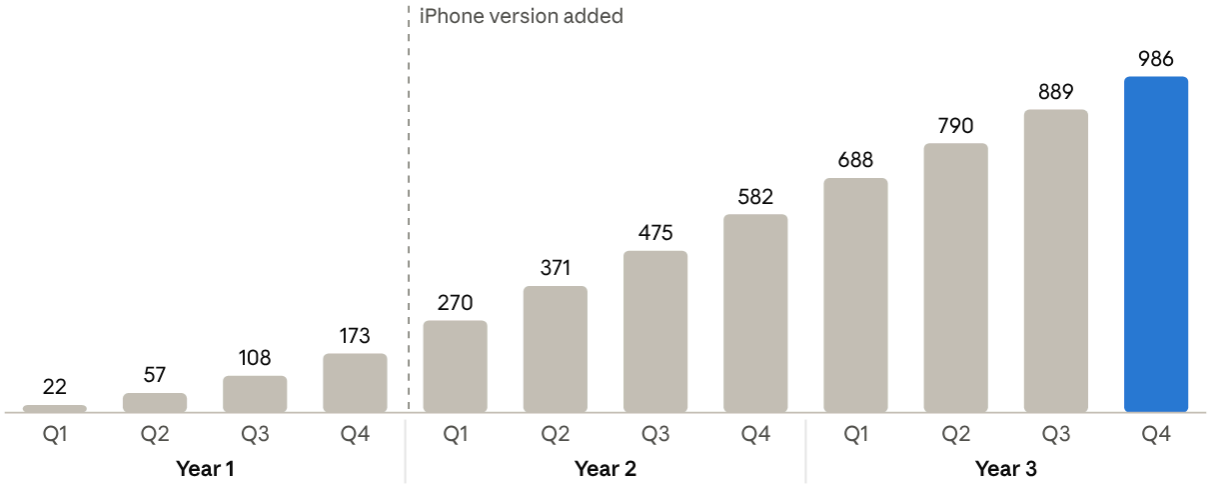
One easy saving: if testing shows the cheaper Claude Haiku 5.5 writes guides that are just as clear, the Claude cost drops to well under 1p a question.

Sales forecast

On the expected plan, Ask Mavis has about 170 paying subscribers after year 1, 580 after year 2 and about 1,000 after year 3.

About 1,000 paying subscribers by the end of year 3

Paying subscribers at the end of each quarter, expected case · 28,216 installs over 3 years



Ask Mavis forecast model, expected case · 36 months from launch

Growth jumps at the start of year 2, when the iPhone version opens the app to about 30% more people and the first yearly plans renew.

What the forecast assumes

Assumption	Value	How sure
Installs from ads	38 per £100	UK averages; tested in launch month
Installs from word of mouth, press and groups	50 in month 1, growing by 40 a month in year 1, 20 a month in year 2 and 10 a month in year 3	**The biggest unknown**
iPhone version	Adds 30% more installs from year 2	Estimate
Installs that pay for Plus	5%	Common for free-plus-paid apps; test it
Payers choosing yearly (or a gift)	60%, paid up front	

Assumption	Value	How sure
Monthly subscribers who cancel	6% a month	Cautious
Yearly subscribers who renew	70%	Estimate

Profit and loss

On the expected plan, profit before tax is about £820 in year 1 (after start-up costs), £7,600 in year 2 and £13,500 in year 3.

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
What customers pay	£3,790	£14,530	£26,180
Less Google's 15%	−£570	−£2,180	−£3,930
Money you receive	**£3,220**	**£12,350**	**£22,250**
Facebook ads	−£1,400	−£1,800	−£3,000
Fixed running costs	−£300	−£540	−£540
Claude (paying and free users)	−£440	−£2,400	−£5,240
Start-up costs	−£260	£0	£0
Profit before tax	**£820**	**£7,610**	**£13,470**
Profit margin (of money you receive)	25%	62%	61%

Money is counted when it's paid, so a yearly plan bought in March counts in full in March. Figures are rounded to the nearest £10.

Profit is before paying yourself and before tax. As a sole trader, this profit is your income. The first £12,570 of total income each year is tax-free (the personal allowance), and the first £1,000 of trading income is tax-free under the trading allowance. If you also have a job, tax and National Insurance on this profit could take about 28% (20% income tax plus 6% to 8% Class 4 NI, approximate; check GOV.UK).

Watch the Claude line. By year 3, free users' questions cost more than paying users' questions. If it grows faster than this, move to Claude Haiku 5.5 or lower the free allowance from 3 questions a month to 2.

Break-even

About 70 paying subscribers cover all the monthly costs in year 1, including £100 a month of ads; without ads it's just 14.

What one subscriber brings in each month, on average:

- Monthly plan: £2.54 after Google's cut (40% of payers).
- Yearly plan or gift: £21.24 a year, about £1.77 a month (60% of payers).
- Blended: about **£2.08 a month**, less about 30p for Claude = **about £1.78 a month** towards costs.

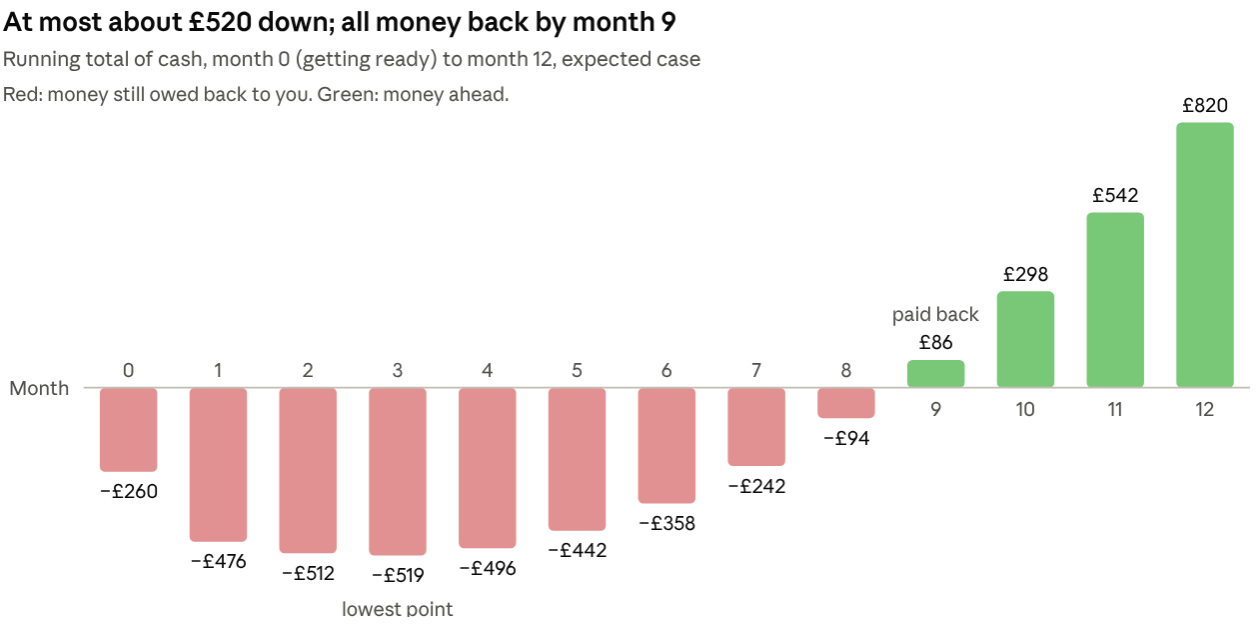
Monthly costs	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Fixed costs	£25	£45	£45
Facebook ads	£100	£150	£250
Total	**£125**	**£195**	**£295**
Paying subscribers needed	**About 70**	**About 110**	**About 170**
Subscribers needed with no ads	About 14	About 25	About 25

On the forecast, Ask Mavis passes 70 subscribers in month 7 and stays well above the line after that. (Each month makes a small profit from month 4, because yearly plans are paid up front.) It has made back every pound spent by **month 9**.

The break-even number is small because costs are small. That's the safety net: if growth is slow, cut the ads and the app still pays for itself with a few dozen subscribers.

Cash flow: the first 12 months

The most you'll be out of pocket is about £520, in month 3; after that, more comes in than goes out every month.



Ask Mavis forecast model, expected case · months 0 to 12

Month 0 is the four weeks of getting ready; month 1 is launch month, with the £300 ad test. Hover over a bar to see the money in and out that month.

Keep a buffer of £600 set aside before you start, so a slow first few months never become a worry.

Scenarios

Even in the worse case the most at risk is about £1,050, and the app still pays back in year 3; in the better case it pays back by month 5.

	Worse	Expected	Better
What changes	Half the word of mouth; 3% of installs pay	As in the forecast	1.5× the word of mouth; 7% of installs pay
Installs over 3 years	About 15,600	About 28,200	About 40,900
Paying subscribers after year 3	About 330	About 990	About 2,000
Profit, year 1 (after start-up)	−£1,050	£820	£3,690
Profit, year 2	£710	£7,610	£18,470
Profit, year 3	£1,560	£13,470	£32,330
Most money at risk	About £1,050	About £520	About £410

	Worse	Expected	Better
All money back by	Month 28	Month 9	Month 5

What to do in the worse case: by month 3 you'll know. If fewer than 3% of installs are paying, or word of mouth is under 100 installs a month, stop the ads. In the worse case that's actually better for you: the most at risk falls to about £700, and the app pays back by month 15 instead of month 28. Spend the time on free sessions and charity partners instead.

What to do in the better case: keep ads at a level where a paying customer costs under £21, bring the iPhone version forward, and consider paid help with customer emails.

Risks and how to handle them

The biggest risk is trust: older people are rightly wary of anything that might be a scam, so the app must look and act safe from the first screen.

Risk	What could go wrong	What we do
Trust	People think the app itself is a scam	Never ask for passwords, card details or codes in the app. No adverts. A real UK contact on the website. Charity partners vouch for it.
Slow word of mouth	Fewer people come than forecast	Check at month 3; cut ads and lean on free channels (see Scenarios). Costs are low enough to wait.
Wrong advice	A Claude-written guide gets a step wrong	Built-in guides are checked by hand. Every guide ends with who to call. A "This didn't help" button flags bad answers.
Claude costs rise	Heavy free use eats the profit	A monthly spending limit on the API key; switch to Claude Haiku 5.5; lower the free allowance.
Health and money	Someone treats the app as medical or financial advice	Guides only cover using the technology; they point to the GP, 111, 999 and the number on the bank card.

Risk	What could go wrong	What we do
Google rejects the app	Launch is delayed	Use Google Play's own payments, a clear price and easy cancelling. Allow two weeks for review.
Facebook ads rejected	Ads stopped, or the account restricted	Never mention the viewer's age; start small; verify the business page.
The name	Someone else owns "Ask Mavis"	There is an ASK MAVIS business in Canterbury, and Malaysia Airlines has an AI helper called Mavis. Do a UK IPO trademark search before printing much. The name lives in one place in the code, so it's cheap to change.
Brand names	Netflix or McDonald's object	Only name them to describe the problem; never use their logos or suggest they endorse us.
Copycats	A bigger company copies the idea	Move fast, win trust locally and build charity partnerships.
You	It all depends on one person	Everything is kept in GitHub and written down; costs stay low enough to survive a quiet month.

Legal, tax and admin

Start as a sole trader (free), pay the ICO fee, and move to a limited company only if profits grow past about £15,000 to £20,000 a year.

Sole trader or limited company?

	Sole trader	Limited company
Cost to set up	Free, with HMRC	£100 at Companies House
Paperwork	One Self Assessment tax return a year	Company accounts, a confirmation statement, a company tax return; most people pay an accountant (about £500 to £1,000 a year, approximate)

	Sole trader	Limited company
If things go wrong	You're personally responsible	The company is responsible, not you
Best for Ask Mavis	**Now**	**Later**, once profit is steady or if you take on bigger risks

Register with HMRC as self-employed by 5 October after the end of the tax year you start trading in.

Checklist

Task	Cost	When
Register as a sole trader with HMRC	Free	Month 0
Pay the ICO data protection fee	£52 a year	Month 0, before handling anyone's data
Write a plain-English privacy policy and terms	Free	Month 0; Google Play requires a privacy policy and a data safety form
Google Play account and closed testing	About £20	Month 0. New personal developer accounts must run a closed test with testers for 14 days before going public, so your 15 testers count twice
Trademark search on the UK IPO site	Free	Month 0, before printing leaflets in bulk
Register the trademark (Classes 9 and 42)	£170 online for one class, £50 for each extra	Once the name is settled and money allows
Business bank account	Free (many have no monthly fee)	Month 0, to keep app money separate
Keep records of money in and out	Free (a spreadsheet works)	Every month
VAT	Not needed	Only if takings pass £90,000 a year

Data and consumer rules

- **UK GDPR:** speech is turned into text on the phone; only the typed problem goes to the server and Claude. Don't store names alongside questions. Check Anthropic's commercial terms on how API data is handled.
- **Subscriptions:** clear price, a reminder before a yearly plan renews, and easy cancelling. New UK subscription rules under the Digital Markets, Competition and Consumers Act 2024 point the same way; check when they start.
- **Not medical or financial advice:** say so in the terms, and keep guides to using the technology.

These costs and rules were correct to the best of our search; check GOV.UK, the ICO and the UK IPO before paying anything.

Next steps: the first 30 days

In the next 30 days, spend about £260 to get Ask Mavis tested, legal and submitted to Google Play.

Week 1: the paperwork

- [ ] Register as a sole trader with HMRC (free).
- [ ] Open a free business bank account.
- [ ] Pay the ICO fee (£52).
- [ ] Search the UK IPO trademark register and Google Play for "Ask Mavis".
- [ ] Buy a domain name (about £15).

Week 2: the app

- [ ] Put the server online and add a Claude API key with a £20 monthly limit.
- [ ] Add Plus subscriptions through Google Play.
- [ ] Write the privacy policy and terms in plain English.
- [ ] Join Google Play (about £20) and start the closed test.

Weeks 3 and 4: testing

- [ ] Test with 15 older people, starting with your nan's friends. Watch, don't help, and write down where they get stuck.
- [ ] Fix what confused them.
- [ ] Take photos and short videos of your nan using it (with her permission).
- [ ] Print the first 100 leaflets.
- [ ] Book the first free help session at a library or lunch club for launch month.

Then: launch in week 5, following the *Marketing Playbook*, and check the real numbers against this plan at month 3.